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GAMING



Google bets on STAN, an Indian social gaming platform



Jagmeet Singh — 10:05 AM PDT · August 1, 2025

Google has backed [STAN](#), an Indian social gaming platform that connects gamers with creators, communities, and publishers.

Google's investment comes as part of an \$8.5 million equity funding round, which also saw investment from Japanese gaming giants Bandai Namco Entertainment, Square Enix, and Reazon Holdings. Aptos Labs and King River Capital, as well as existing backers General Catalyst and GFR Fund, also participated. Google joined the round via its [AI Futures Fund](#), which [launched](#) in May to support startups building with its AI tools.

STAN, headquartered in Singapore, is trying to position itself as a gaming community platform to rival Discord, but its approach to the market is quite different. STAN lets users earn in-app currency called "Gems" by winning games like Krafton's Battlegrounds Mobile India, Garena's Free Fire Max, Minecraft, Call of Duty, or casual titles like Ludo and Snakes & Ladders.

The app also lets creators set up chat rooms called Clubs, which are channels tailored for each game on the platform. While anyone can join these Clubs, they need to pay a social currency to access the "gaming experiences" that creators offer. The startup takes a commission from these transactions.

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH



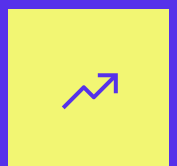
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The primary attraction seems to be the in-app currency, however, as it can be redeemed for vouchers on various e-commerce platforms like Amazon, PhonePe, and Flipkart. Users can also earn currency via referrals, a spin-to-win wheel, and daily rewards.

It appears STAN's monetization model is what sets it apart: Users can earn rewards through interactions, unlike on Discord, where chatting or participating in communities doesn't earn users much, apart from clout.

Nonetheless, STAN wants to shadow Discord. The company claims it has already garnered over 25 million downloads on the Play Store and App Store altogether, and it has around 5.5 million monthly active users.

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IMAGE CREDITS:STAN

“STAN is the hangout place for gamers. It’s a place where gamers come and make friends, play with each other, talk to each other, sort of a fusion of social and gaming,” said Parth Chadha, co-founder and CEO of STAN, in an interview.

Chadha credits the platform’s features for its traction so far. Initially, creators had to contact the company’s team to start streaming, but last year, the startup opened the platform to user-generated content, allowing anyone to go live. That shift helped drive both downloads and engagement, the CEO said.

STAN also works with game publishers, studios, and developers, including Krafton, Garena, and Roblox, who pay the startup to connect them with gamers and creators on the platform.

Chadha told TechCrunch that in the past two quarters, nearly 100 game publishers, studios, and developers have joined the platform, and it is bringing more than 20 on board each month.

“That is turning into a very interesting business stream as we speak,” he said.

Looking ahead, STAN plans to leverage Google’s backing to use AI to improve moderation.

Currently 70% to 80% of moderation on STAN is already handled by AI, Chadha said. A human moderation team manages the rest, but the startup plans to reduce that further by using AI.

Additionally, STAN aims to bring AI-powered toolkits for creators, including the ability to produce avatars and memes, as well as tools for quick replies and filtering out chats.

“There are a lot of interesting plug-and-play models, which we and the Google team are working together to leverage and scale the business,” he stated.

STAN isn’t the first Indian startup to be backed by Google’s AI Futures Fund. That distinction goes to [Toonsutra](#), a startup using AI to power an [immersive comic-reading experience](#).

Google confirmed to TechCrunch that it has invested over \$5.5 billion in India to date, including in startups Toonsutra, STAN, Pixxel, and Adda247.

Although STAN’s app is currently geo-restricted to India, the platform still sees 5% to 6% of its engagement coming from users abroad, who often access it using Indian phone numbers and accounts. Over the next year, the startup plans to expand internationally, starting with the Indian subcontinent, and will later target Southeast Asia and Latin America.

The startup was profitable for a few months, the CEO said, but decided to spend some money to scale. Now it aims to achieve profitability in 2027, he added.

Currently, the startup employs about 40 people; less than 30 of them work in product engineering.

With this raise, STAN’s total equity funding now stands at around \$15 million.



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Google's AI coding agent Jules is now out of beta

Jagmeet Singh — 9:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Google on Wednesday launched its AI coding agent, Jules, out of beta, just over two months after its [public preview debut in May](#).

Powered by Gemini 2.5 Pro, Jules is an asynchronous, agent-based coding tool that integrates with GitHub, clones codebases into Google Cloud virtual machines, and uses AI to fix or update code while developers focus on other tasks.

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

Google [initially announced](#) Jules as a Google Labs project in December and made it [available to beta testers](#) through a public preview at its I/O developer conference.

Kathy Korevec, director of product at Google Labs, told TechCrunch that the tool's improved stability drove the decision to take it out of beta after receiving hundreds of UI and quality updates during its beta phase.

"The trajectory of where we're going gives us a lot of confidence that Jules is around and going to be around for the long haul," she said.

With the wider rollout, Google introduced structured pricing tiers for Jules, starting with an "introductory access" free plan capped at 15



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individual daily tasks and three concurrent ones, down from the 60-task limit during beta. Jules' paid tiers are part of the Google AI Pro and Ultra plans, which are priced at \$19.99 and \$124.99 a month, and offer subscribers 5x and 20x higher limits, respectively.

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"we got a little bit of feedback from users that it [the privacy policy] wasn't as clear as we thought it was, and so most of it is just responding to that. We didn't change anything about what we're doing on the training side, but we changed the language," Korevec said.

During the beta, Google said that thousands of developers tackled tens of thousands of tasks, resulting in over 140,000 code improvements shared publicly. Initial feedback led the Google Labs team to add new capabilities, including reusing previous setups for faster task execution, integrating with GitHub issues, and supporting multimodal input.





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IMAGE CREDITS: JULES / X

The two primary users of Jules so far are the AI enthusiasts and professional developers, Korevec said.

By running asynchronously in a virtual machine, Jules stands apart from top AI coding tools like Cursor, Windsurf, and Lovable, which all work synchronously and require users to watch the output after each prompt.

“Jules operates like an extra set of hands ... you can basically kick off tasks to it, and then you could close your computer and walk away from it if you want and then come back hours later. Jules would have those tasks done for you, versus if you were doing that with a local agent or using a synchronous agent, you would be bound to that session,” Korevec explained.

This week, Jules received a deeper integration with GitHub to [open pull requests automatically](#) — just like it could open branches — and a feature called [Environment Snapshots](#) to save dependencies and install scripts as a snapshot for faster, more consistent task execution.

From vibe coding to mobile use, beta trials informed Jules’ development

Since entering public beta, Jules has logged 2.28 million visits worldwide, 45% of them from mobile devices, per data from market intelligence provider [SimilarWeb](#), reviewed by TechCrunch. India was the top market for traffic, followed by the U.S. and Vietnam.

Google did not share specifics on Jules' user base and its top geographies.

Korevec told TechCrunch that during the beta, the team observed that many people used Jules from traditional vibe-coding tools to either fix bugs that might have been implemented or extend the vibe-coded project to make it more production-ready.

Originally, Jules required users to have an existing codebase. But Google soon realized many potential users — like those trying other AI tools — might want to explore it without one. Korevec said the company quickly enabled Jules to work even with an empty repository. That helped increase its scope and usage.

Google Labs' team also noticed an increasing number of users accessing Jules through their mobile devices. Although the tool does not have a dedicated mobile app, Korevec said users were accessing it through its web app.

“Since it’s a big use case that we’re seeing emerging, we’re absolutely exploring what the features are that people need on mobile a lot more,” she noted.

Alongside beta testers, Korevec stated that Google already uses Jules to help develop some projects internally, and there is now a “big push” to use the tool on “a lot more projects” at the company.

Topics: [AI](#) [Google](#) [Google Jules](#) [jules](#)



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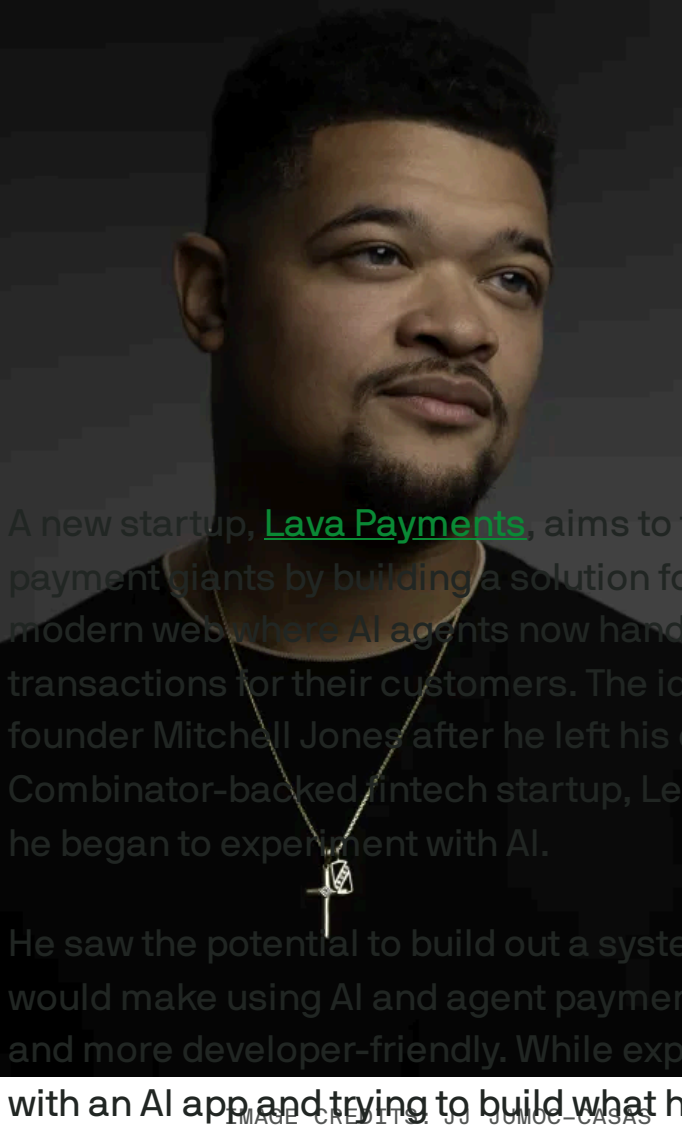
STARTUPS



Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build

digital wallets for the ‘agent-native economy’

Dominic-Madori Davis — 8:45 AM PDT · August 6, 2025



A new startup, [Lava Payments](#), aims to take on payment giants by building a solution for the modern web where AI agents now handle transactions for their customers. The idea came to founder Mitchell Jones after he left his earlier Y Combinator-backed fintech startup, Lendtable, as he began to experiment with AI.

He saw the potential to build out a system that would make using AI and agent payments simpler and more developer-friendly. While experimenting with an AI app and trying to build what he thought was something simple, he realized he quickly spent more than \$400 trying to build a basic form-filling agent.

“I kept running into the same issue,” he told TechCrunch. “I was using the same underlying models and tools again and again, but through different wrappers or platforms.” And each time, he had to start a new subscription, re-authenticate, and pay separately, “even though I was already paying for access to the core model.”

“That felt fundamentally broken,” he continued. “I didn’t want to keep rebuying access to the same thing under a different wrapper. What I wanted was a single wallet, one set of credits, and the ability to

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move between tools and providers without starting over every time so I could pay for what I was using.”

He decided to launch Lava Payments as a solution.

Lava is a digital wallet that lets merchants use usage credits to facilitate transactions.

The idea is that one set of credits working across merchants and services makes it easier for autonomous agents to make payments without needing human intervention. It works like this: A merchant can enable the Lava wallet for their customers to use and upload (credits) money to. Once a customer does that, they can take that money and use it at any merchant that also accepts Lava and any of the foundational models, like GPT and Claude, on a “pay as you go basis,” Jones said.

So, rather than having to pay for each tool, a user buys a one-time usage credit that AI agents can simply charge as they perform various tasks. No more asking the user to approve transaction after transaction.

“Without Lava, agents can’t move smoothly through the internet because they constantly get blocked when it comes time to pay,” he said. He used Google as an example, saying every time a person opens Google Maps, they don’t have to pay Google for that map, as they’ve already paid Verizon and AT&T to access the internet.

On Wednesday, the startup announced a \$5.8 million seed round led by Lerer Hippeau.

Others in this space include startups like [Metronome](#).

“We see the world as very interconnected,” Jones said about what makes his product different. “What

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we're really focused on is building [for the] agent-native economy."

Born to a working family in Dayton, Ohio, Jones said his parents always told him the best way to get ahead was to work hard, save money, and get a good education.

"You know, a lot of the things that most people are told," he recalled, when speaking with TechCrunch.

Jones took that advice to heart. He got a good education (Yale), held some good jobs (Goldman, Meta), and then founded some companies (the fintechs Parable and Lendtable, the latter of which was YC S20).

Jones said he met his lead investors for Lava because he went to high school with [Will McKelvey, now an investor at Lerer Hippeau](#). He said McKelvey has been following his career for a while and always wanted to work together someday, and Lava Payments was that someday.

Others in the round included Harlem Capital, Streamlined Ventures, and Westbound. The fresh capital will be used for hiring, building products, and developing go-to-market strategies.

Overall, Jones is ready for Lava to be the "invisible layer that kind of powers the AI web," he says, especially as AI agents find themselves more and more in the checkout line.

"We should be enabling agents to move, transact, and build without friction," he said.

"We want to make sure that AI is something that can be used by every single person, even a kid from Dayton, like myself."

The title of this piece was updated to properly reflect what the company does.

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